

Celebrity contagion and the value of objects

REPLICATION AND EXTENSION REGISTERED REPORT OF NEWMAN ET AL. (2011)

8 JULY 2026



Research Question

- Why are celebrity-related objects so expensive to buy?
- They're a lot more expensive even though it's basically the same thing!

Possible reason 1: Association

- Item is closely associated with the celebrity due to provenance
- Item would serve as a positive reminder of the celebrity

But why do “bad” celebrities also get this effect? Are they actually liked?

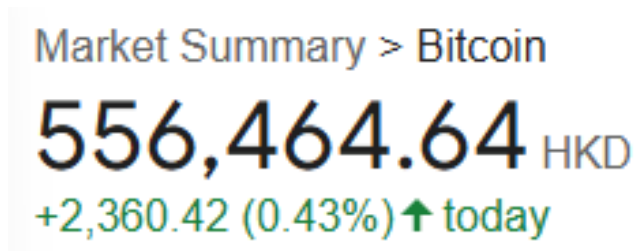
Unabomber auction nets \$190,000

The very technology that the Unabomber railed against during his murderous spree was used Thursday to help some of his victims.

Possible reason 2: Market demand

- Items that a specific person owns is rare
- Buy rare thing -> Rare thing is now rarer -> price rises further -> earn money

But why would it even be valued in the first place?



Possible reason 3: Essence transfer

- Name in the literature: “Contagion”
- Belief that a person’s “essence” can be transferred through physical contact
- Item is perceived as being “imbued” with authenticity

Essence transfer

- Examples:
 - Men are willing to pay more for a T-shirt if an attractive woman touches it (Argo et al., 2008)
 - Golfers played better when handed a putter that they were told belonged to a professional (Lee et al., 2011)
 - Handmade products are preferred as gifts for loved ones due to the “love” embedded in these products (Fuchs et al., 2015)

Main targets

- We want to be able to:
- (1) Separate these effects and see how they act differently
- (2) See how these different effects interact with other factors
- Replication of a paper on this topic

Replications?

Psychology replication crisis:

- Many studies are found to not “work” when tried again (Klein et al., 2015)
- Especially serious in social psychology
- Movement to replicate and verify popular studies with a bigger sample size

An internal investigation resulted in a 1,200-page report that found Gino, a tenured professor, "committed research misconduct intentionally, knowingly, or recklessly" and recommended the university initiate steps leading to her termination.

On September 11, 2024, the judge dismissed all of Gino's claims against the Data Colada defendants (defamation and other claims), and dismissed Gino's defamation and certain other claims (such as violation of privacy) against the Harvard University defendants,

Simplified study design (Newman et al., 2011)

Study 1: Have participants some things that are worn

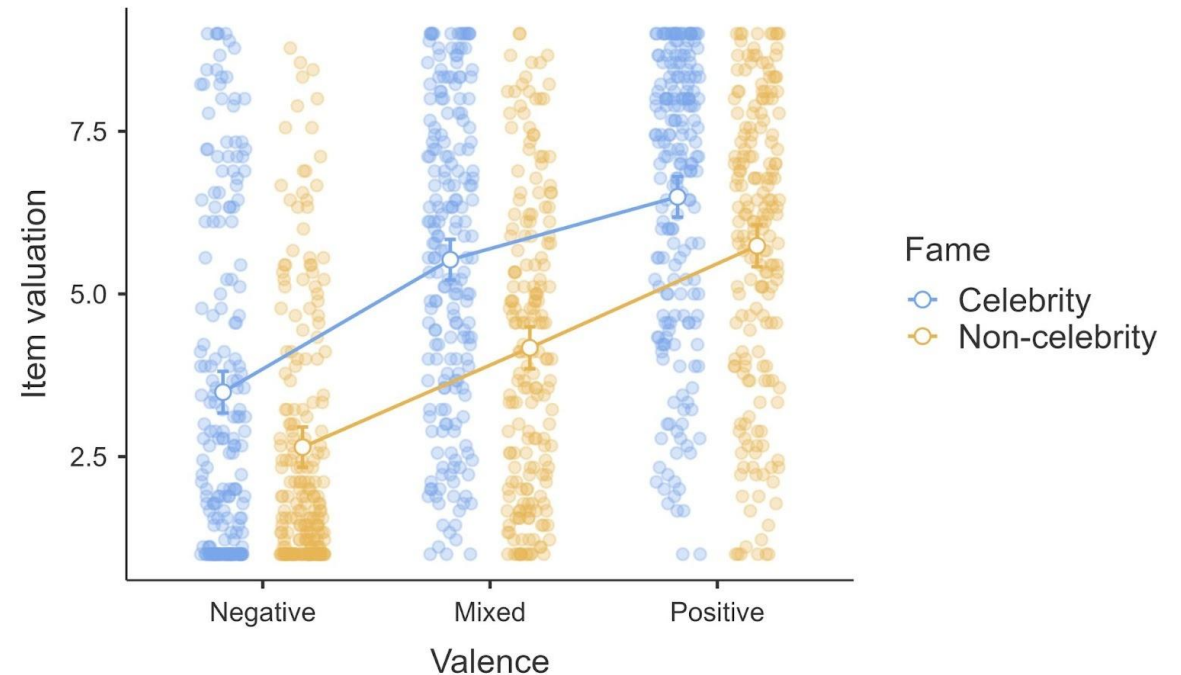
- Who owned the thing: Six different conditions (3x2 between subjects)
 - 3x valence: Positive, mixed, negative
 - 2x fame: Celebrity, non-celebrity
- DVs:
 - Item value (do you want to own the thing?)
 - Market demand (do you think people want to buy the thing?)
 - Essence transfer (do you want to touch the thing?)

Results (Study 1)

Study 1 DV: **Item value**

Valence effect: Large ($\eta^2 = 0.22$)

Fame effect: Small ($\eta^2 = 0.04$)



Results (Study 1)

Study 1 DV: **Item value**

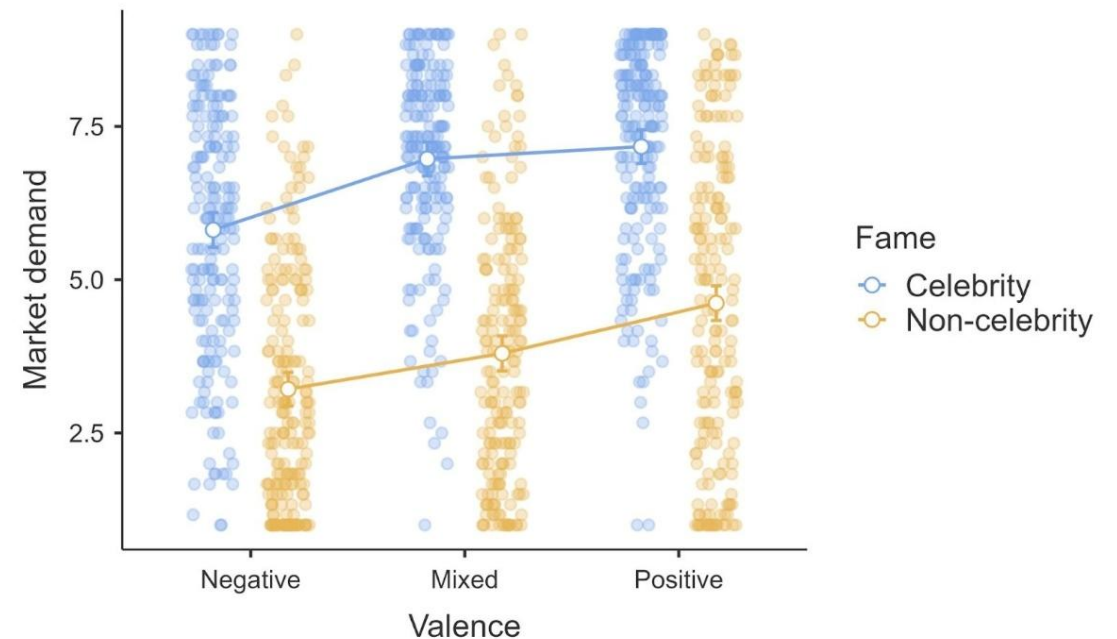
Valence effect: Large ($\eta^2 = 0.22$)

Fame effect: Small ($\eta^2 = 0.04$)

Study 1 DV: **Market value**

Valence effect: Small ($\eta^2 = 0.05$)

Fame effect: Large ($\eta^2 = 0.31$)



Results (Study 1)

Study 1 DV: **Item value**

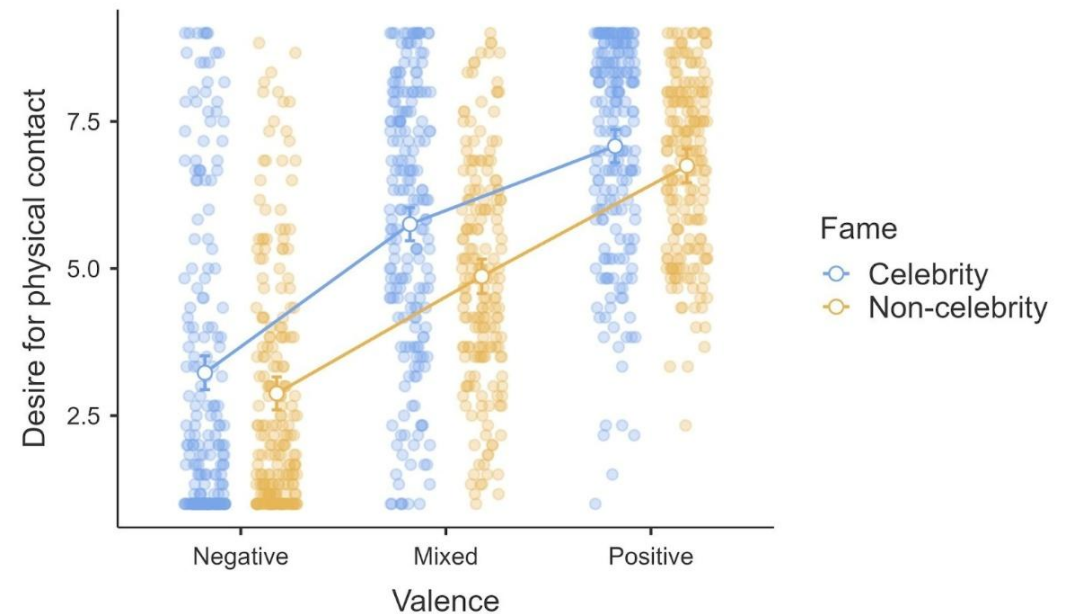
Valence effect: Large ($\eta^2 = 0.22$)

Fame effect: Small ($\eta^2 = 0.04$)

Study 1 DV: **Essence transfer**

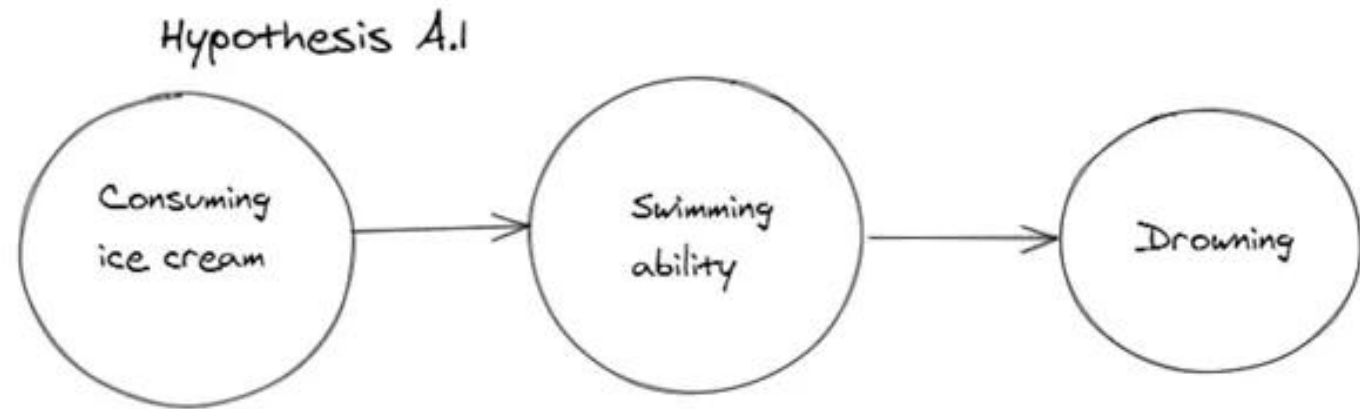
Valence effect: Large ($\eta^2 = 0.37$)

Fame effect: Small ($\eta^2 = 0.01$)



Study 1 discussion

- Valuation is close to essence transfer in how it's affected by fame and valence
- But correlation is not causation!!
- How do we cause a causation to happen?



Simplified study design (Newman et al., 2011)

Study 2: Have participants compare how much they want to buy a sweater

- Type of manipulation: Eight different conditions (2x2x2 between subjects)
 - 2x valence: Positive, negative
 - 2x manipulation type: Physical contact, market demand
 - 2x direction type: Highlighted, decreased
- Participants first split into two groups:
 - Positive: Name your favourite celebrity X
 - Negative: Name a famous evil person X
- Participants asked: How willing are you to buy X's sweater over a normal one?

Simplified study design (Newman et al., 2011)

Study 2: Have participants compare how much they want to buy a sweater

- Participants then went through one of four manipulations:
 - Physical contact, highlighted: This one was their favourite and they wore it often
 - Physical contact, decreased: They never even opened the box that it came in
 - Market demand, highlighted: There is a lot of demand for items owned by X
 - Market demand, decreased: There is very little demand for items owned by X
- Participants asked again: Given this new information, now willing are you to buy X's sweater over a normal one now?

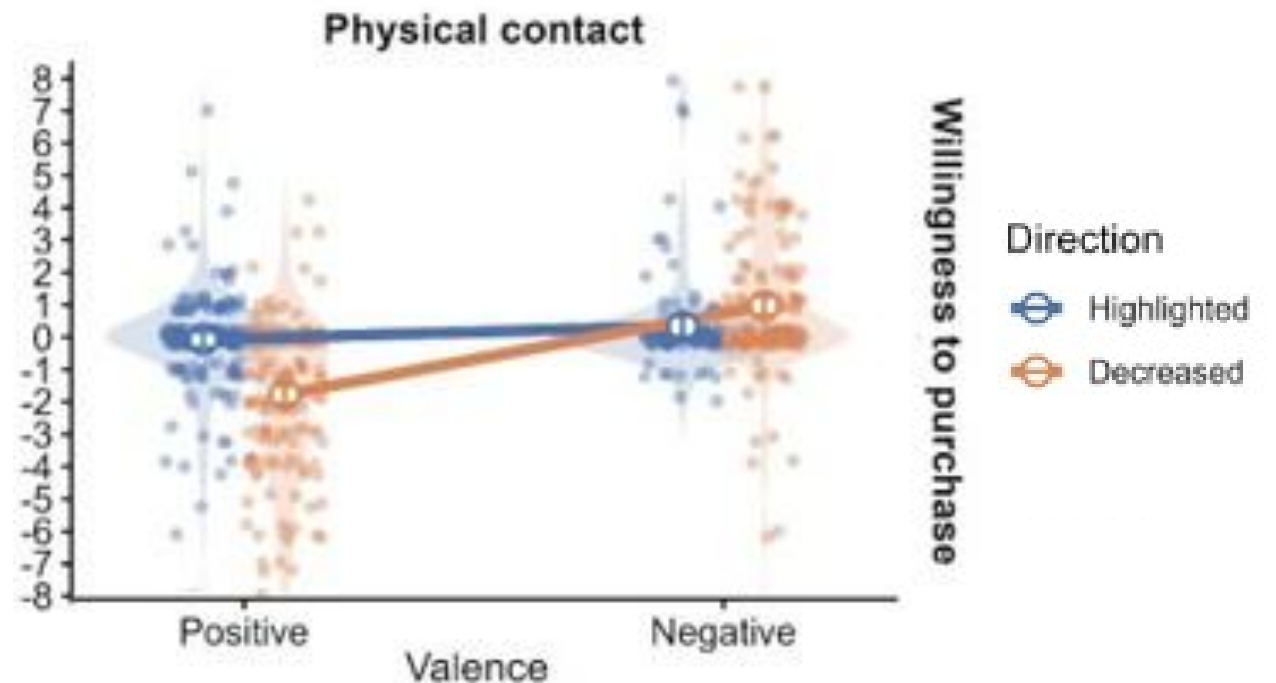
Results (Study 2)

Study 2: **Physical contact**

Main effects of valence and direction ($\eta^2 = 0.12, 0.01$)

Interaction effect ($\eta^2 = 0.07$)

-> Decreasing physical contact causes willingness to purchase to significantly drop comparatively for positive celebrities



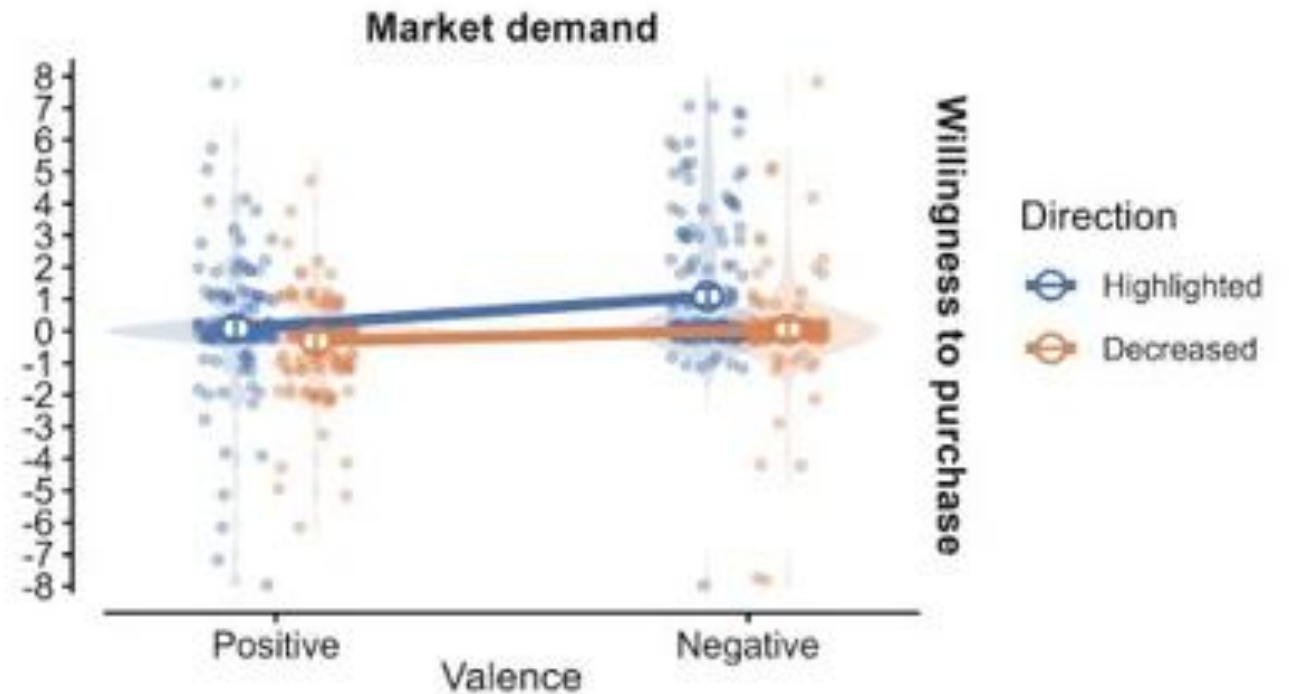
Results (Study 2)

Study 2: Market demand

Main effects of valence and direction ($\eta^2 = 0.04, 0.03$)

No interaction effect!
($p = .085, \eta^2 = 0.01$)

-> Decreasing market demand causes willingness to purchase to significantly increase comparatively for negative celebrities



Study 2 discussion

- Separation of factors that affect valuation
- Essence transfer as one of the drivers
- It seems that:
 - Essence transfer affects positive individuals more -> good luck charm?
 - Market value affects negative individuals somewhat -> bought as a flex?

However...

- It seems that essence transfer actually doesn't need physical contact?
- E.g.
 - People may believe that they can sense “emotional residue” in their surroundings (Savani et al., 2011)
 - Original manufacturing locations (Newman & Dhar, 2014) and early serial numbers (Smith et al., 2015) are better because they are “closer” to the origin

Extension of study 1:

Extension: add a small piece to the original study

- Who owned the thing: Six different conditions (3x2 between subjects)
 - 3x valence: Positive, mixed, negative
 - 2x fame: Celebrity, non-celebrity
- DVs:
 - Item value (do you want to own the thing?)
 - Market demand (do you think people want to buy the thing?)
 - Essence transfer (do you want to touch the thing?)
 - **Essence transfer, non-physical (do you want to video call the person?)**

Results (Extension)

Essence transfer (physical):

Valence effect: Large ($\eta^2 = 0.37$)

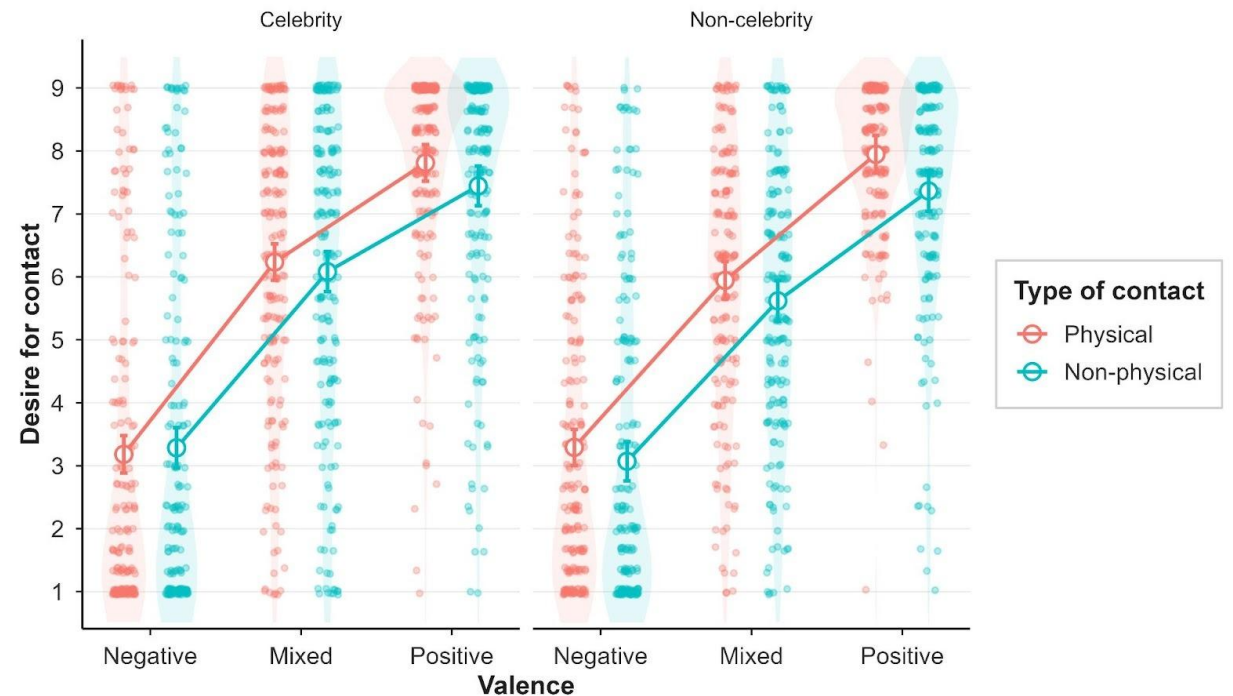
Fame effect: Small ($\eta^2 = 0.01$)

Essence transfer (non-physical):

Valence effect: Large ($\eta^2 = 0.37$)

Fame effect: Small ($\eta^2 = 0.01$)

All interaction effects are of negligible size ($\eta^2 < 0.01$)



Conclusions

- Different factors affect valuation of celebrity goods
- Essence transfer by contact is a main driver
- It affects positive individuals stronger than market value
- Essence transfer may also occur without physical contact